

ECCLESIA DISCIPLESHIP & COMMISSIONING

EDC 105: DISCIPLESHIP FOUNDATIONS

(Part One: Biblical, Theological, and Practical Basis of Discipleship)

The New Birth is the entrance into life in Christ, but discipleship is the process by which that life is formed, matured, and expressed. Salvation brings us into Christ; discipleship conforms us to Christ. Scripture never presents conversion without formation. To be born again is to be summoned into a life of following, learning, obedience, and transformation.

Jesus did not merely call people to believe in Him; He called them to follow Him. The Great Commission itself is not centered on decision but on discipleship:

“Go therefore and make disciples of all nations...” (Matthew 28:19)

Thus, discipleship is not an optional stage for advanced believers. It is the normal Christian life.

Biblical Definition of a Disciple

A disciple is one who learns Christ, follows Christ, and becomes like Christ.

The Greek word for ‘teach’ in Matthew 28:10 is **mathētēs** from **mathētēuo** which means a *learner, apprentice, or one under discipline*. In biblical usage, a disciple is not merely a student of ideas but a follower of a Person.

Jesus’ invitation makes this clear: “*Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men.*” (Matthew 4:19)

Here, discipleship involves:

- A call (“Follow Me”)
- A process (“I will make you”)
- A purpose (“fishers of men”)

Paul later reflects this reality when he writes: “*Until Christ is formed in you.*” (Galatians 4:19)

Discipleship, therefore, is Christ being formed in the believer over time.

The call to make disciples is not optional; it is commanded. The Great Commission underlines both the universality and the purpose of discipleship:

“*Go therefore and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you*” (Matthew 28:19–20).

Discipleship involves three inseparable components:

1. Conversion: Bringing people into the life of Christ through faith and repentance.
2. Instruction: Teaching God’s Word, doctrine, and ethical living.

3. Formation: Guiding believers into practical obedience, mission, and Christlike character.

Biblical discipleship naturally follows progressive stages:

1. Awakening: Recognition of sin, need for salvation, and the call of Christ (John 3:3; Acts 2:37–38)
2. Initiation: Receiving new birth and foundational teaching (Romans 6:4; Colossians 2:6–7)
3. Formation: Establishing habits of prayer, study, and obedience (1 Timothy 4:7–8)
4. Empowerment: Training in ministry and gifts (Ephesians 4:11–13)
5. Multiplication: Developing others into disciples (2 Timothy 2:2)

These stages ensure discipleship is holistic, lifelong, and generational.

Paul reiterates this principle in 2 Timothy 2:2: “*The things you have heard me say... entrust to reliable people who will also be qualified to teach others.*”

Discipleship is therefore both relational and generational, extending beyond a single individual to the community and future leaders.

The Call to Discipleship: Cost and Commitment

Jesus never hid the cost of discipleship. He made it explicit from the beginning.

“If anyone desires to come after Me, let him deny himself, take up his cross daily, and follow Me.” (Luke 9:23)

Discipleship requires:

- Self-denial (the dethroning of self-rule)
- Cross-bearing (daily submission to the will of God)
- Following (ongoing obedience, not a one-time act)

Jesus further warned that discipleship must be entered deliberately and soberly:

“*Whoever does not bear his cross and come after Me cannot be My disciple.*” (Luke 14:27)

Thus, discipleship is not about convenience or religious activity. It is about total allegiance.

The Relationship Between Salvation and Discipleship

Salvation is by grace; discipleship is the response to grace.

Paul makes this balance clear: “*For by grace you have been saved through faith... not of works.*” (Ephesians 2:8–9) “*For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works.*” (Ephesians 2:10)

Discipleship does not earn salvation, but salvation produces discipleship. Where there is genuine faith, there will be transformation, obedience, and growth.

James reinforces this truth: “*Faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead.*” (James

2:17)

Discipleship is the visible evidence of an invisible faith.

Learning Christ: Formation of Mind and Life

Discipleship involves learning, not merely information, but transformation of thinking and living.

Paul describes this process: *“You have not so learned Christ... put off the old man... and be renewed in the spirit of your mind.”* (Ephesians 4:20–23)

A disciple learns:

- Christ’s teaching
- Christ’s ways
- Christ’s character

Jesus Himself stated: *“Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart.”* (Matthew 11:29)

To learn Christ is to submit to His yoke, allowing Him to shape values, priorities, decisions, and conduct.

Discipleship cannot be separated from holiness. Christ calls His followers to be holy as He is holy (1 Peter 1:15–16). Holiness shapes:

- Character: Alignment with God’s nature
- Speech: Reflecting love, truth, and edification
- Conduct: Ethical integrity in relationships and ministry
- Witness: Credibility and fruitfulness in the world (Matthew 5:16)

Without holiness, discipleship becomes superficial; it is obedience, not mere activity, that confirms genuine following.

Discipleship and Obedience

Discipleship is inseparable from obedience.

Jesus said plainly: *“If you love Me, keep My commandments.”* (John 14:15)

Again: *“You are My friends if you do whatever I command you.”* (John 15:14)

Biblical discipleship does not redefine obedience as legalism. Rather, obedience is the fruit of love and relationship.

John affirms: *“For this is the love of God, that we keep His commandments. And His commandments are not burdensome.”* (1 John 5:3)

A disciple is not sinless, but is responsive, teachable, and submissive to God’s authority.

Discipleship and the Word of God

The foundation of all discipleship is Scripture. The Word of God is central to discipleship.

Paul instructs Timothy: *“All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting, and training in righteousness”* (2 Timothy 3:16–17)

Jesus said: *“If you abide in My word, you are My disciples indeed.”* (John 8:31)

The Word:

- Corrects thinking (2 Timothy 3:16)
- Shapes character (Psalm 119:9)
- Produces spiritual maturity (Hebrews 5:12–14)

Early believers were marked by devotion to doctrine:

“They continued steadfastly in the apostles’ doctrine...” (Acts 2:42)

There is no biblical discipleship without sustained exposure to Scripture.

Components of Discipleship Foundations

a. Commitment to Christ

A disciple is first and foremost a follower of Christ, not a collector of knowledge or religious rituals. Commitment entails:

- **Obedience:** *“If you love me, keep my commandments”* (John 14:15)
- **Loyalty:** Choosing Christ over family, culture, or personal desire (Luke 14:26)
- **Dependence:** Walking daily under Christ’s authority and provision (Matthew 6:33)

b. Spiritual Formation

Spiritual formation undergirds discipleship. It encompasses:

- **Sanctification:** The Spirit-led transformation of character (2 Corinthians 3:18)
- **Prayer and Meditation:** Communication with God and internalization of His Word (Psalm 1:2–3)
- **Application of Doctrine:** Translating biblical truth into daily living (James 1:22)

c. Community Engagement

Discipleship is relational and communal. Scripture repeatedly emphasizes the role of the faith community:

- Mutual accountability (Proverbs 27:17)
- Collective worship and instruction (Acts 2:42)
- Shared mission (Matthew 10:1–8)

Isolation weakens discipleship; structured fellowship strengthens it.

Discipleship in Community

Discipleship is personal, but never isolated.

Jesus discipled within relationship. Paul discipled Timothy. Barnabas discipled Paul. The church is designed as a discipling community.

Hebrews exhorts: *“Exhort one another daily... lest any of you be hardened through the deceitfulness of sin.”* (Hebrews 3:13)

And again: *“Let us consider one another in order to stir up love and good works.”* (Hebrews 10:24–25)

True discipleship thrives in accountability, instruction, correction, and encouragement.

Discipleship and Mission

The ultimate goal of discipleship is conformity to Christ and participation in His mission.

Paul writes: *“For whom He foreknew, He also predestined to be conformed to the image of His Son.”* (Romans 8:29)

Disciples are also commissioned: *“As the Father has sent Me, I also send you.”* (John 20:21)

A mature disciple becomes a disciple-maker.

Paul’s model reflects this: *“The things that you have heard from me... commit these to faithful men who will be able to teach others also.”* (2 Timothy 2:2)

Discipleship has both a personal and missional dimension. The disciple is not only transformed but also equipped to impact the world for God.

- Witness: *“You shall be My witnesses... to the ends of the earth”* (Acts 1:8)
- Service: Demonstrating God’s love through action (Mark 10:45)
- Leadership: Raising other disciples and shepherding God’s people (2 Timothy 2:2)

Formation is not only inward; it must bear fruit outwardly.

Conclusion: Discipleship as a Lifelong Journey

Discipleship is not a phase; it is a lifelong walk. From the moment of New Birth to final glorification, the believer is being shaped by Christ through the Spirit, the Word, and the community of faith.

Jesus’ final words remain the Church’s mandate:

“Teaching them to observe all things that I have commanded you.” (Matthew 28:20)

Where salvation begins the journey, discipleship sustains it, deepens it, and fulfills it.

Part Two:
Practical Application, Challenges, and EDC Context

1. Practical Implementation of Discipleship Foundations

Foundational principles of discipleship must be translated into consistent practice. Knowledge alone is insufficient; the believer must live out what is learned, allowing Christ to shape character, priorities, and ministry.

Personal Devotion

Disciples must cultivate daily intimacy with God. This includes:

- Prayer and meditation on Scripture (Psalm 5:3; Joshua 1:8)
- Journaling and reflection to internalize lessons (Habakkuk 2:2–3)
- Obedience in small, consistent actions (Luke 16:10)

These practices create spiritual muscle memory, shaping the believer to respond rightly under pressure and temptation.

Community Engagement

Discipleship thrives in relational settings:

- Mentorship: A mature believer guiding a newer disciple, as Paul guided Timothy (2 Timothy 2:2)
- Accountability partnerships: Encouraging perseverance and truth-telling (Proverbs 27:17; James 5:16)
- Group study and worship: Reinforcing doctrine, love, and service (Acts 2:42–47)

The relational aspect ensures that discipleship is not theoretical but tested, applied, and reinforced.

Lifestyle Obedience

Living out discipleship foundations daily involves:

- Ethical integrity in work, speech, and relationships (Ephesians 4:25–32)
- Stewardship of resources as a reflection of God's lordship (1 Peter 4:10)
- Serving and ministering with humility, reflecting Christ's example (Mark 10:43–45)

Discipleship is visible: it transforms the way one lives in every sphere.

2. Common Challenges in Discipleship

Even grounded believers face obstacles that can hinder the formation of a disciple:

A. Spiritual Complacency

Many believers settle into comfort zones, thinking conversion is enough. Paul warns:

“Therefore let us not sleep, as others do, but let us watch and be sober” (1 Thessalonians 5:6)

Complacency stunts growth, making the believer vulnerable to temptation and doctrinal error.

B. Overemphasis on Knowledge Without Practice

Discipleship requires integration of knowledge and obedience. James 1:22–25 highlights the danger of self-deception through knowledge alone. True discipleship walks in what is learned, not simply stores it mentally.

C. Cultural and Worldly Pressures

Modern distractions, societal norms, and worldly ambitions challenge discipleship. Jesus warned: “*The cares of this world, the deceitfulness of riches... choke the word, and it becomes unfruitful*” (Mark 4:19)

Believers must maintain focus on Christ while navigating worldly pressures.

D. Lack of Mentorship

Without guidance from seasoned disciples, growth can be slow or misguided. Paul emphasizes intentional transmission of faith: “*What you have heard from me before many witnesses entrust to faithful men*” (2 Timothy 2:2)

3. Correcting Misconceptions About Discipleship

1. Discipleship is not optional: Every believer is called to follow Christ actively (Luke 14:27).
2. Discipleship is not mere church attendance: True discipleship engages character, mission, and obedience (Matthew 28:20).
3. Discipleship is not instant: Transformation is gradual, requiring discipline, patience, and Spirit-led growth (Philippians 1:6).
4. Discipleship is not legalism: It flows from grace, not duty or fear (Romans 6:14).

4. Leadership Integration in Discipleship

EDC places emphasis on raising leaders who are disciples first. Leadership emerges naturally from strong discipleship foundations:

- **Servant Leadership:** Following Christ’s model of humility and service (Mark 10:42–45)
- **Equipping Others:** Developing new disciples who can teach, lead, and multiply (Ephesians 4:11–13)
- **Character as Authority:** Leadership is credible only when it flows from integrity and holiness (1 Timothy 3:2–7)

Discipleship is therefore foundational for every form of ministry leadership.

Biblical Illustrations of Foundational Discipleship

- **Jesus and the Twelve:** Daily teaching, correction, shared life, and sending them out (Mark 3:13–19; Luke 9:1–6)
- **Paul and Timothy:** Structured instruction and mentoring, preparing Timothy to continue ministry (2 Timothy 2:2)
- **Early Church:** Collective learning and living of faith principles under the apostles’ teaching (Acts 2:42–47)

Each example demonstrates intentional, relational, and practical discipleship integrated with mission.

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